

Skills Assessment

1 Strengths

My two biggest strengths coming into this class are collaborative and technical. In my current role I have worked on two different teams on various projects. As such I am familiar with strategies for managing team wide workload. This applies to tools like github and soft skills such as defining tasks, acceptance criteria, and communicating effectively both in and out of the team. As such I at least have exposure to the strategies used to ensure team members aren't stepping on each others toes and have a unified vision for a project.

My second skill is definitely in my tech stack. Though I wouldn't consider myself an exceptional developer, I am familiar with the tools used in industry data science. One of my old personal projects is a good example of this. It pulls a lot of data off the internet to build various utilities related to a franchise of video games I like. It required web scraping for pulling and cleaning the tables, data engineering skills for building a relational data model for the app and then data wrangling, visualization and simulation skills for the utilities. I've learned a lot of tools over the years, so I'm confident in my ability to pick up anything new I may need.

2 Growth Opportunities

I think my biggest area for growth is in **confidently** communicating my thoughts. My memory can be shaky and my notes disorganized, causing me to second guess myself constantly in the moment. I think with any of these projects that I can put a lot of work into building up domain knowledge and a careful understanding of the data we're provided. I don't need to be an expert on these topics, but surface level reading can make communicating with our client and interpreting our results so much easier. Even a little bit goes a long way here.

Another area for growth is that I often rabbit hole on issues and spend way too much time on little edge cases and bugs that don't matter. With any project, especially ones such as this with a tight deadline, I really want to be better about **documenting** issues and limitations as they come up instead of immediately trying to solve them. Documenting things such as this also helps with client communications, as we can talk to them about what stuff we don't account for or areas where results don't make sense.

3 SMART

Skill 1: Confident and Accurate Project Communication

Specific

I will improve my confidence and information recall skills by maintaining a detailed project information log. This log will summarize key facts about the topic alongside current findings and limitations for our project. This information log may or may not live within the project README itself.

Measurable

As previously stated, this log will track facts, findings and limitations. These can be counted directly and verified for accuracy. The information contained in here should grow through the life cycle of the project.

I should also be studying this document regularly, so before any meeting with a client or professor I should be able to explain the project goal, data basics and a recent result without referring to this log. I will track instances where I slip up and either forget or misrepresent information to others.

Achievable

This task doesn't need to be too time intensive. 15-30 minutes every couple days should be sufficient to both add to and update the log. As such this goal shouldn't dominate my time or cause me to prioritize it over other responsibilities.

Relevant

This skill is extremely relevant. It allows for more seamless and accurate project communication while also enhancing my ability to interpret results. It may even help come up with solutions to problems we run into.

Time-bound

I will have a skeleton of this log created within a week of getting access to the data. I will update this log twice per week during the semester. We can check in on this project log midway through the semester and discuss if it aided in my lack of confidence and recall.

Skill 2: Efficient Problem Scoping & Documentation

Specific

I will improve my initial response to errors, bugs and misunderstandings during the project lifecycle to help curb my habit of rabbit-holing. I will do this by first documenting any data quality concerns, modeling edge cases and bugs **before** I attempt to address them. This information will be tracked either by using the **issues** functionality in github or in a separate markdown file.

Measurable

As stated, I have two possible means of tracking issues in this project. In general though, I will maintain an issues and limitations log. It will provide a description of each problem, a screenshot of the issue if applicable, the current status of the issue and timestamped updates as required.

I will also seek to cap any initial digging into an issue to 30 minutes before I require the creation of said documentation. I will also keep track of any times that I end up rabbit-holing on a problem.

By the end of the project at least 3/4ths of the issues provided should be resolved. That does not mean fixed, but we should have some conclusion we have reached about said issue. Sometimes fixes will fall outside of the project scope.

Achievable

This task should be perfectly reasonable to accomplish and, if anything, may actually make the project itself easier to achieve by avoiding unnecessary wastes of time.

Relevant

All projects run into problems constantly. Whether its a software bug, a data quality issue, a miscommunication on a columns definition or any number of other situations. It is crucial to be able to make clear rational decisions when faced with problems and clearly defining them is a very important first step to accomplishing that.

Time-Bound

Within a week of acquiring the data I will have created a skeleton solution for logging and handling issues. I want this done as soon as possible as the early parts of the project are when issues will be ran into the most. I will update the issue log twice a week which may even be an update showing no new issues.